Fracture with Ukraine will be harder to reverse this time

送信者: EG US Daily 受信日時: 2026-10-20 00:26

【メール原文】

Fracture with Ukraine will be harder to reverse this time. Since taking office, President Donald Trump has changed his position on Ukraine multiple ti

US Daily
Customize Email Preferences

Fracture with Ukraine will be harder to reverse this time

19 Oct 2026 11:24 EDT Discover more on the Portal

*
Fracture with Ukraine will be harder to reverse this time
*
Don’t expect Trump’s Netanyahu endorsement to matter in US midterms
*
Georgia governor’s race a problem for Ossoff’s presidential ambitions

Fracture with Ukraine will be harder to reverse this time. Since taking office, President Donald Trump has changed his position on Ukraine multiple times, shifting from coercive demands of Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky in the Oval Office to emphatic suggestions of US support. The sharp turn away from Kyiv over the last week will prove harder to reverse than prior shifts in US position, placing additional burden on European support to Ukraine but not likely moving the conflict toward resolution.

*
Zelensky’s public comments over the past week—namely his rejection of Trump’s demand that he halt strikes on energy targets—will inflame one of Trump’s key points of frustration in recent weeks, and likely require some form of public concession from Zelensky to smooth over. In the meantime, Trump will likely be drawn to the prospect of high-profile engagement with Russia, such as the trilateral summit with China proposed by Russian President Vladimir Putin.
*
Bipartisan criticism of Trump will be too weak to force a shift. Blocking parts of Trump’s legislative agenda is the most viable point of leverage that Congressional supporters of Ukraine have at present, and several GOP House defense hawks are threatening to do exactly that. However, following through on threats to block defense spending increases (the core of Trump’s legislative asks) or force a government shutdown are harder than making the threat—a point that means the White House is unlikely to reverse course in the near future.
*
Trump’s likely escalation against Iran in mid-November limits space for reversal (see Hormuz attacks likely to compel US escalation after midterms , 15 October 2026). Trump wants the optics of a diesel deal with Russia even if the price impacts are negligible, and further price increases linked to escalation of US airstrikes will only amplify that desire. Trump's apparent belief his engagement with Putin has

isolated Iran from Russia—as laid out in his comments this weekend--also argues against reversing course on Ukraine.

Don’t expect Trump’s Netanyahu endorsement to matter in US midterms. President Trump’s endorsement of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu for re-election yesterday might have importance consequences for the upcoming Israeli election, but it’s likely to be a nothingburger in terms of domestic US politics.

*

Gaza did matter to the 2024 election, albeit in a limited fashion: Majority-Muslim communities, particularly in the state of Michigan, shifted heavily away from Democrats, with both Trump’s and third parties’ vote shares increasing significantly.

*

But that marriage of convenience has broken down amid the ongoing war in Gaza and the war with Iran, meaning that Trump’s decision to align himself formally with Netanyahu isn’t likely to sway additional voters. Moreover, Israel—and foreign policy writ large—has never been a major issue for the US electorate in recent years, especially in midterm elections.

*

Even in the Michigan Senate race, the effect of the endorsement is likely to be minimal at best. The Democratic nominee, Abdul El-Sayed, already has strong appeals among Muslim voters and far-left voters, the two groups most animated by Gaza, so the Netanyahu endorsement probably won’t give him additional juice in the tight race.

Georgia governor’s race a problem for Ossoff’s presidential ambitions. Senator Jon Ossoff’s (D-GA) likely re-election romp this year will supercharge already-considerable hype about his prospects as a 2028 presidential candidate, given his track record of winning in purple states. But if Republicans win the Georgia governor’s mansion, those ambitions will be in trouble.

*

If Ossoff wins the presidency and vacates his seat, the governor would get to appoint a replacement to fill the seat ahead of a special election that wouldn’t take place until 2030. A Republican governor would almost certainly appoint a Republican, reducing Democrats’ Senate ranks by one.

*

If Ossoff is the nominee, Democrats would, in effect, need to win one additional Senate seat to offset a Republican replacement. If the Senate is split 50-50 after the 2028 election, Democrats would lose their majority. It would be impossible to pass a party-line reconciliation bill, typically the marquee piece of legislation for any administration.

*

The situation is different if Senator Raphael Warnock (D-GA), also a potential 2028 contender, chooses to run. Warnock is up for re-election in 2028, so likely would not seek another term if he’s also running for president. While Democrats wouldn’t relish having to defend an open seat, this could be less risky from a tactical perspective.

Quote of the Day

"I've never seen anything like that from the President." - Vice President JD Vance responding to a question about whether he has seen corrupt activity in the White House at a CBS town hall this weekend. Democrats have successfully capitalized on corruption concerns in their midterm messaging, and it is an issue they are nearly certain to attack Vance on as the 2028 presidential race gets started.

On the Radar

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

Clayton Allen
Practice Head, United States
+1 202.903.0027
allen@eurasiagroup.net
Noah Daponte-Smith
Senior Analyst, United States
daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net
Kendal Walker
Senior Analyst, United States
walker@eurasiagroup.net
Jason Walter
Researcher, United States
walter@eurasiagroup.net
EG US Daily
unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net
© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.
X-HG-DocID cmvfedi8khss807mv6nl6g4tt

Opt Out | Customize Email Preferences